

"Distress migration, which has been our main concern, has reduced in recent years. Migration within the state has increased compared to earlier years...it's a good sign"

— S.S. NEGI, *Vice-chairman, Migration Prevention Commission*

to return, partly to care for his ageing parents and partly, as he puts it, "to build a peaceful life for myself...and do something". Now, he laments the decay that has set in his native land.

PERILS OF MIGRATION

In Kothar village, Dr Raghuveer, economics professor at Bal Ganga Degree College, puts it bluntly. "Uttarakhand does not really have an economy of its own. Most people depend on religious tourism, and that too lasts barely six months a year and benefits only those on specific routes." He believes the state must rediscover its own strengths—herbs, mountain crops and small-scale produce, rather than relying on pilgrims and tourists. "Young people today chase only two things—a government job or work in a hotel or bar," he says. "This is a sign of shrinking ambition."

That frustration is evident in the next generation. In Tehri, 21-year-old Samar Vijay Singh Rana recently gave up on the Agniveer recruitment drive. "I don't want it anymore, I am preparing for other government exams. Everyone's asking what I will do after serving for four years," he says.

Prof. M.M. Semwal, who heads the department of political science at the HNB Garhwal Central University, warns of a series of serious consequences of sustained outmigration. "If it continues the same way, the border areas will be left empty, posing serious national security risks. The focus on disaster management over sustainable development has drained resources.

The next big threat to the hills is the upcoming delimitation in 2026. If it is based purely on population, the plains, which are just 14 per cent of the state, will get more seats, while the 86 per cent hilly regions will lose political weight. It might cause further outmigration," he says.

The state government has been citing the Centre's Vibrant Villages Programme as part of its revival efforts. Launched in 2023 for the 'comprehensive development' of villages along India's northern borders, in Uttarakhand, the scheme promises new infrastructure, housing and livelihood options in the remote areas of Pithoragarh, Chamoli and Uttarkashi. Officials are hoping roads, homestay incentives and digital connectivity will "bring life back to the borders".



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A few houses have already been built in Milam (Pithoragarh district), one of the oldest ghost villages, abandoned after the 1962 war, and often showcased as validation for the scheme. Before the war, Milam was a thriving trade hub on the Indo-Tibetan route, home to around 500 Bhotiya families known for their trans-Himalayan trade. When the border closed, most of them migrated. Today, Milam remains mostly in ruins, but a few families return in summer to grow medicinal plants and high-altitude crops.

In April this year, the Centre approved Vibrant Villages Programme-II, extending it to a few more strategic villages in border states. Anuradha Pal, additional secretary (rural development), says new homestays have come up in some border villages under the scheme. "But it is too early to comment on the overall impact on reverse migration," she adds.

S.S. Negi, vice-chairman of the migration prevention commission, however, feels the trend may finally be shifting. "Distress migration, which has been our main concern, has come down. Also, migration within the state has increased; it's a good sign," he says.

Negi's reasoning is based on people like Nautiyal. After returning home, he started farming, experimenting with kiwis, a crop that thrives in the mild climate of the lower Himalayas. Soon, he added citrus fruits, apples, and even nettle leaves, and began collaborating with local women's self-help groups to process their produce. What began as an experiment has grown into a brand, Rangilo Chhabilo, which sells jams, juices, cookies and more across nine product lines. "We are doing what the state should be doing," says Deepak.

And therein lies the crux of the matter: can Uttarakhand rediscover itself, offer its people more reasons to stay? ■